

HR Round, English, and the Final Checklist

HR round answers, the words to know, and what to read at 07:30

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Study pack - part 7 of 10

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Part A - The HR round

The HR round is the **last** stage tomorrow, after the pre-placement talk, the interaction/GD round and the technical round. Your faculty listed questions 78, 79 and 80 - why BT, why should we hire you, strengths and weaknesses. Here are those and the others that always come.

The register rule again: no “ownership”, no “I led”, no “I’m an expert”. Your CV says intern. Be the person that CV describes - capable, curious, easy to teach, easy to work with.

Tell me about yourself

See document 00 for the full script. Structure: who you are → how you work → what you are looking for → why this role.

Why do you want to join BT?

Full answer in document 05. Short version: the scale of the network and the fibre programme; the fact that the part of software you enjoy most is keeping things running; and wanting to be properly taught rather than learning alone in fragments.

Why should we hire you?

The trap here is arrogance. The fix is to answer with **fit**, not superiority.

“I don’t think I’d be the most experienced person you talk to - I know I’d be starting behind someone with actual network operations experience. What I think I’d bring is three things.

First, I’m used to things being broken and having to work out why calmly. Running my own deployments meant that when something went down at midnight, there was nobody else, so I learned to be systematic instead of panicking.

Second, I can explain technical things in plain language. I’ve had to do that with business owners who weren’t technical at all, and I’ve seen how much it matters when the person on the other end doesn’t understand what you’re saying.

And third, I’m genuinely trying to move into this area, not passing through it. So I’d put the effort into learning it properly.”

What are your strengths and weaknesses?

Strengths - pick two, and give evidence for each. No adjectives without proof.

“The first is that I’m methodical when something is broken. I don’t start changing things randomly - I try to narrow down where the problem actually is first. That came from debugging deployments where guessing just wasted hours.

The second is that I explain things simply. I’ve spent a fair amount of time explaining technical problems to people who aren’t technical, and I’ve got reasonably good at not using jargon.”

Weakness - it must be real, and you must say what you are doing about it. A fake weakness is an instant red flag.

“An honest one: I’ve mostly worked alone on my projects, so I’ve built the habit of trying to solve everything myself before asking anyone. Sometimes that’s cost me hours on something a colleague could have answered in two minutes. I’ve started forcing myself to set a limit - if I’m stuck past a certain point, I ask. Working in a team on a shared queue would actually help me with that, because asking is the normal way things work there.”

Why that weakness is a good choice for this role: it is genuinely true of solo developers, it is not fatal in an operations context, and the fix you describe - asking sooner - is exactly the behaviour a first-line team wants. **Avoid** “perfectionism”, “I work too hard”, or anything that is a disguised strength.

Where do you see yourself in five years?

“Realistically, in five years I’d want to be someone the team trusts with the harder incidents rather than the routine ones - and to actually understand networks properly by then, ideally with a certification behind it rather than just experience. Beyond that I’d be interested in the automation side, because I can write code and a lot of operations work can be scripted. But I don’t want to skip the learning part to get there. The first couple of years I’d just want to become genuinely good at the job.”

*Note: mentioning automation is smart - the JD literally lists Automation - but only **after** you have said you want to learn the fundamentals first.*

Are you comfortable with shift work / night shifts?

Network operations is 24/7. This will probably come up. **Answer honestly** - if you say yes and mean no, you will be miserable and they will lose someone in six months.

If yes: > “Yes. I’ve read that it’s a 24/7 function, and that makes sense - the network doesn’t stop. I’ve done plenty of late nights on my own projects, and I’d rather know the rota in advance than pretend it isn’t part of the job.”

If you have real reservations, say so calmly and ask about the rota. A measured question is fine; discovering it after joining is not.

How do you handle pressure / a difficult customer?

“By slowing down rather than speeding up. When something’s broken and someone is frustrated, the useful thing is usually to first make sure I actually understand what they’re seeing, and tell them what I’m doing and what I’ve found. Most frustration I’ve seen comes from not knowing what’s happening, not from the wait itself. And I try not to take it personally - they’re annoyed at the situation.”

Tell me about a time you failed / made a mistake

Have one real, small, recoverable story. For instance:

“I once broke a live site by changing an Nginx config on the server without testing it first - I made the edit, reloaded, and the site went down. It was only a few minutes because I could revert it, but it taught me two things: test the config before reloading, and keep a copy of what worked. That’s roughly the same habit as having a rollback plan for a change, which I gather is standard practice here.”

Why this story is good: it is genuinely your mistake, it is small enough to be forgivable, and the lesson maps directly onto change management in their world.

Are you willing to relocate?

Answer truthfully. If Kolkata is where you want to be, say so with a reason - you are from here, your family is here - and note you are open to travel or training elsewhere if needed.

Do you have any offers / are you interviewing elsewhere?

Be honest and brief. Do not use it as leverage, and do not badmouth SAP or any other process. “I’ve been through a few campus processes; this is the one that fits what I want to do.” Never criticise a company that rejected you - it reads badly and they may know people there.

Any questions for us?

Always yes. The list is in document 05. Ask two.

Part B - The English vocabulary component

The written vocabulary test was in the online assessment, which you have already cleared - so this section is now lower priority than it was. Keep it for two reasons: a panel occasionally throws in a quick word question, and using precise words well is part of how spoken fluency is judged.

The spoken side matters far more now - two of tomorrow's stages are conversations and one may be a group discussion. That is covered in **document 09**, which is the one to read if you are short of time.

Ten minutes here, not thirty.

Words that appear constantly in these tests

Word	Meaning	Synonym	Antonym
Abundant	plentiful	ample, copious	scarce
Alleviate	to ease or lessen	relieve, mitigate	aggravate
Ambiguous	open to more than one meaning	vague, unclear	explicit
Candid	honest and direct	frank, forthright	evasive
Coherent	logical and consistent	logical, lucid	disjointed
Concise	short and clear	succinct, brief	verbose
Diligent	careful and hardworking	conscientious	negligent
Enhance	to improve	augment, boost	diminish
Feasible	possible to do	viable, practicable	impossible
Meticulous	very careful about detail	thorough, precise	careless
Mitigate	to make less severe	reduce, lessen	intensify
Obsolete	out of date	outdated, defunct	current
Prudent	sensible and cautious	judicious, wise	reckless
Redundant	unnecessary / duplicated	superfluous	essential
Resilient	recovers quickly	robust, tough	fragile
Scrutinise	to examine closely	inspect, examine	skim
Tenacious	persistent	determined, dogged	irresolute
Transparent	open, easy to see through	candid, clear	opaque
Viable	workable	feasible	unworkable
Volatile	unstable, changes fast	unpredictable	stable

*Bonus: **redundant** and **resilient** are also networking words - redundant links, a resilient network. If a vocabulary question uses one, using it in a networking sentence is a nice touch.*

Commonly confused pairs - these are the favourite test items

Pair	The difference
affect / effect	affect is usually the verb (it affects performance); effect is usually the noun (the effect was severe)
its / it's	its = belonging to it; it's = it is
their / there / they're	possessive / place / they are
your / you're	possessive / you are
then / than	then = time; than = comparison
accept / except	accept = receive; except = excluding
advice / advise	advice = noun; advise = verb
principal / principle	principal = main, or head of a school; principle = a rule or belief
stationary / stationery	stationary = not moving; stationery = paper and pens
complement / compliment	complement = completes; compliment = praise
lose / loose	lose = misplace; loose = not tight
fewer / less	fewer for countable things (fewer packets); less for uncountable (less bandwidth)
between / among	between two; among more than two
assure / ensure / insure	assure a person; ensure a thing happens; insure against loss

Grammar traps in sentence-correction questions

- **Subject-verb agreement:** "The list of devices **is** long" - the subject is *list*, not *devices*.
- **Each / every / everyone are singular:** "Everyone **has** submitted", not *have*.
- **Neither/either:** "Neither of the routers **is** responding."
- **Tense consistency:** do not switch between past and present inside one sentence.
- **Dangling modifiers:** "Having checked the cable, the fault was found" is wrong - the fault did not check the cable. "Having checked the cable, I found the fault."
- **Double comparatives:** "more better" is wrong.
- **Preposition pairs:** *different from*, *capable of*, *responsible for*, *consists of*, *comply with*, *interfere with*.

Speaking clearly - which is what they are really testing

The vocabulary test is a proxy. The real question is whether a UK customer on a call could follow you easily.

- **Slow down.** Nervous candidates speed up. Speaking slightly slower than feels natural is almost always an improvement.
- **Short sentences.** One idea per sentence. Long sentences are where clarity dies.
- **Do not pad.** "Basically", "actually", "like", "you know", "as such" - cut them.
- **Finish your sentences.** Trailing off makes a right answer sound uncertain.

- **If you need a moment, take it.** “Let me think about that for a second” is completely acceptable and sounds far better than filler noise.
 - **If you do not understand a question, ask.** “Sorry, could you repeat that?” or “Do you mean X or Y?” - in a role that lists active listening as a requirement, this is a positive signal.
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Part C - The final checklist

Tonight, before you sleep

- ☐ Document 01 read, and the quick-fire table said out loud
- ☐ **Document 09 read - the GD rules decided in advance**
- ☐ Subnetting: three examples worked **on paper**
- ☐ OSI seven layers, in order, without looking
- ☐ The port table
- ☐ “What happens when you type google.com” said out loud, start to finish
- ☐ The ChatterBox pitch, route, payload and schema written on paper from memory
- ☐ Alarms set. **Two of them.**
- ☐ Resume printed - **bt_resume.pdf**, the version with your photo. Take **two or three copies**
- ☐ Clothes, ID, and anything the placement cell asked for, out and ready

At 07:30 tomorrow

Read only these three things. Nothing new.

1. The quick-fire table at the end of document 01.
2. The one-page GD reminder at the end of document 09.
3. The 10-minute revision list at the end of document 02.
4. This checklist.

The 60 seconds before you walk in

1. **Order of the day:** pre-placement talk, then the interaction/GD round, then technical, then HR.
The GD comes before you get to show any networking - see document 09.
 2. **Short answers, then stop.** Two or three sentences. Let them ask.
 3. **Listen to the whole question.** It is a listed requirement for the job.
 4. **“I don’t know” is a valid answer** - followed by what you do know and how you would find out. Bluffing is the only losing move.
 5. **You are an intern-level developer who wants to learn networks.** Not an owner, not an expert. Humble and curious wins here.
 6. **Lead them to ChatterBox** when they ask about projects.
 7. **Your prepared route is POST /api/messages.** Your prepared schema is the four ChatterBox tables.
 8. **BT Group**, not “British Telecom”. Allison Kirkby. One Braham, London. Openreach is separate. Fibre to two-thirds of the UK.
 9. **Escalating is not failure** - it is the job, done properly and on time.
 10. Breathe. Speak slowly. You have prepared more than most people in that room.
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One last thing

You did not get SAP. That happened, and it is genuinely not evidence about your ability - campus processes reject good engineers constantly, for reasons that often have nothing to do with the candidate.

What you did do afterwards is read the job description properly, work out what this interview actually tests, and prepare for that instead of for a generic one. That is the difference between the first attempt and this one.

Go and be the person who is easy to teach and calm when things break. That is genuinely who they are looking for.